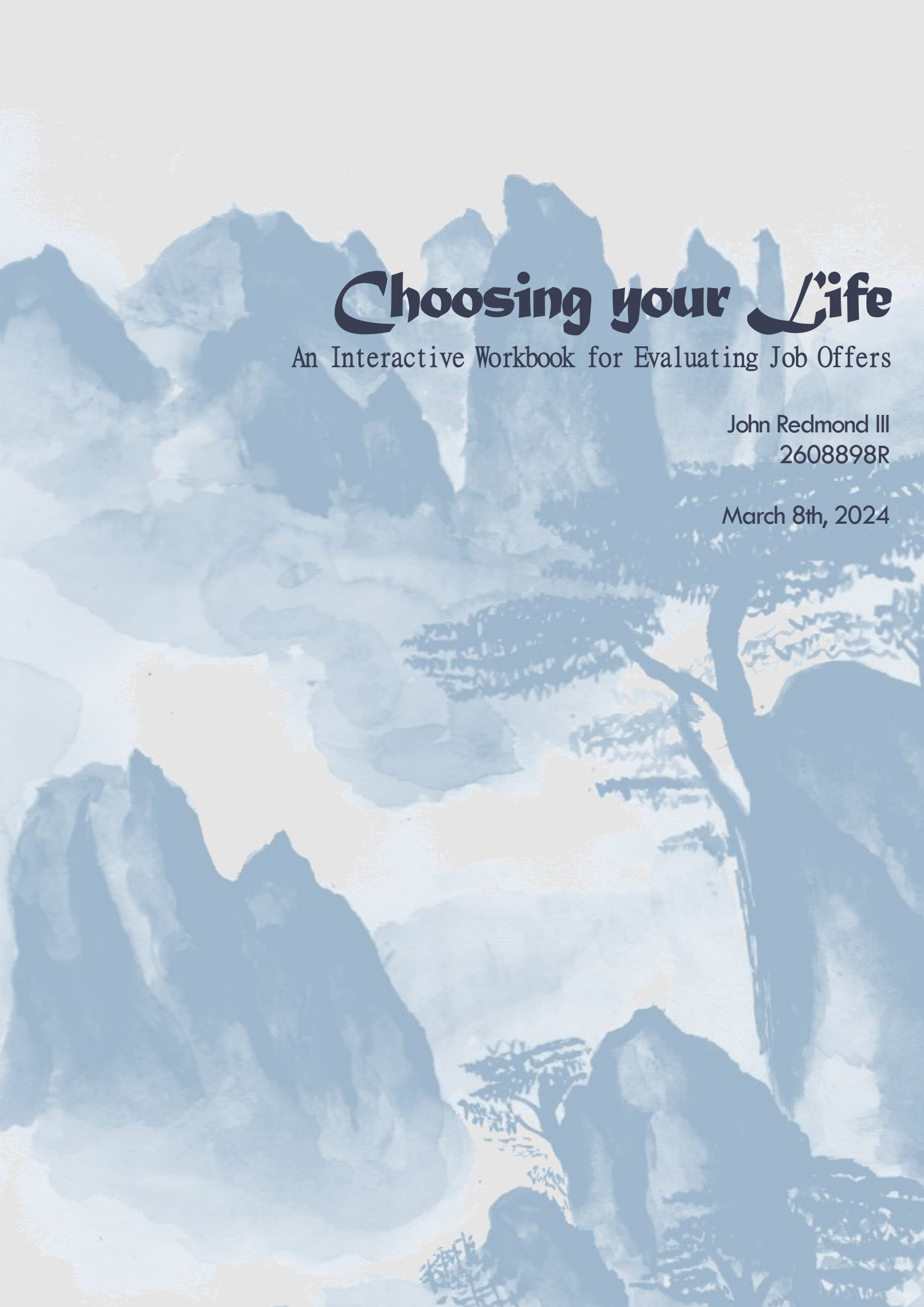


The background of the entire page is a traditional Chinese ink wash painting. It depicts a rugged mountain landscape with several peaks. In the foreground on the right, a large, dark pine tree with dense needles stands prominently. The mountains are rendered with varying shades of blue and grey ink, creating a sense of depth and texture. The overall style is minimalist and artistic, typical of traditional Chinese landscape art.

Choosing your *Life*

An Interactive Workbook for Evaluating Job Offers

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Preface

It's easy to feel in life that things aren't going your way. At times situations may feel stagnant or like nothing will work out. Sometimes we feel we don't have a choice or that it's too late to make a change, but there's always more options. It's imperative to remind ourselves that we have control of our lives. We have the responsibility and privilege of choosing what we do with our time, and we should all strive to find what drives us and brings us joy.

This workbook is designed to provide advice for one of most people's biggest time commitments, their career. Most people will spend over a third of their waking hours working, so choosing a job and building a sustainable career which you enjoy is an important pursuit. In this workbook you'll work through several tools which will guide you to determining if a job position at a particular organisation is likely a good fit, should be considered further (and which aspects should be considered further), or if the position is likely not a good fit.

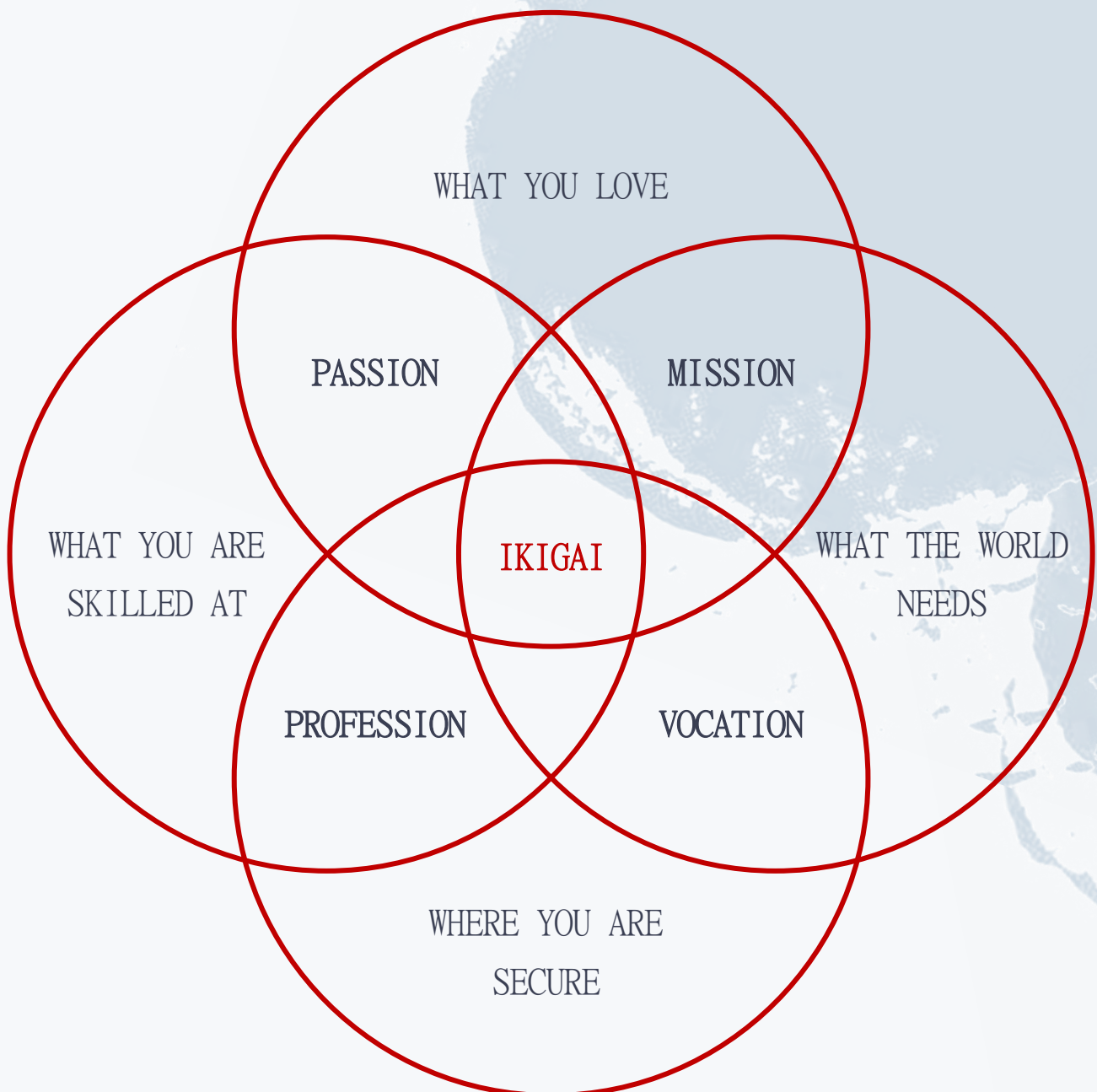
Your personal values, the organisation's values, the organisation's impact on the world, and particulars about the position will all be weighed in the process.

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Approach

The Japanese concept of Ikigai is used as a backbone for this workbook's approach. Ikigai translates to "life's purpose" and is a framework to get a greater insight into how a career path or job position provides or fails to provide you a purpose in life. The framework comprises of four categories: love, need, security and skill.



- ♦ The *love* category represents the enjoyment you derive from the immediate work you will do on a daily basis and the long term career path projected from the job position.
- ♦ The *need* category represents how needed the work you are doing is. It is difficult to find motivation if there is no need for the work you do.
- ♦ The *security* category represents how much you are paid and how secure your future in the career path is (i.e. how established the organisation is).
- ♦ Finally, the *skill* category represents how skilled and experienced you are at the work.

When all four of these categories are fulfilled, a position can be said to be someone's Ikigai, their purpose in life.

It can be difficult to find a place to start and to think about these categories objectively, so some key questions are presented, and tools are used to break the task into a more analytical and wholistic method. Using these tools and questions a score from 1 to 3 will be determined for each category which will ultimately be used to provide advice on and insight into the job position in question.

Ikigai Categories: Love

To determine if the love category is satisfied, you first need to understand what brings you joy. This can be influenced by what you value from day to day and your goals and ambitions. Once these are clearer to you, it becomes easier to determine if you would enjoy the job position, if it would facilitate your goals and if it would align with your values.

Comfort (Daily Values)

This first exercise is designed to help you determine your comfort zone in a workplace by presenting you with some common situations and finding your preference. You'll then be able to compare these against what you know about the environment and type of work of the position directly. Take note when answering these prompts that it can often be beneficial to stretch yourself past your comfort zone. For each of the following questions, circle the option you personally find the most appealing.

- I. | Mostly work from home | Mostly work in office | Many Locations |
- II. | Collaborative work | Solo work |
- III. | Physical work | Office work |
- IV. | Fixed schedule | Flexible schedule |
- V. | Hierarchical management | Flat management |
- VI. | Consistent project/work | Variable projects/work |
- VII. | Manager | Technical worker | Non-technical worker |

After answering these questions for yourself, go back using a different pen colour and circle the relevant option to the position you are considering. If the position aligns with all of your preferences, add one point to the Love category. If the position aligns with four or more of your preferences but not all of them, add a half point. In this case you may have to adapt to some things, which may be difficult, but may also lead to new discoveries. In the case less than four of your preferences align with the position then don't add anything.

LOVE SCORE: []

Goals (Vision and Mission)

To feel a sense of fulfilment in a position it is important that you understand and are passionate about the cause you would be contributing to with your work. This step looks at the values of the organisation as a whole using the vision and mission statements of the organisation. These are likely both available on the organisation's website, however if they are not then you should try to create them based on what you know. Example statements will be given to facilitate this.

The vision statement is a statement, usually one or two sentences, which encapsulates the organisation's ultimate desired impact they want to have on the world. The vision statement is usually a long term goal and clearly states what the organisation is trying to achieve. The mission statement is similarly a one to two sentence statement but defines the path which the organisation plans to use to make their vision a reality. This usually includes more practical things such as business strategies and is much shorter term than the vision statement.

Try to find the vision and mission statements of the organisation which the position is offered by and write them down below. If you cannot find them, use the example at the bottom of the page and what you can find out about the organisation to attempt to write them yourself.

VISION STATEMENT:

MISSION STATEMENT:

Now think about how much this vision resonates with you personally. Is it something you personally feel you want to exist in the world and want to work towards? If so, then add half a point to the total of the love category. Does the path laid out in the mission statement seem reasonable and agree with your personal morals? If so, then add another half point to the love category.

LOVE SCORE:

EXAMPLE (TESLA)

VISION: CREATE A FUTURE WITH ZERO CARBON EMISSIONS FROM CARS

MISSION: PRODUCE THE BEST POSSIBLE ELECTRIC VEHICLES AND CREATE THE INFRASTRUCTURE TO MAKE THEM VIABLE OPTIONS OVER GAS CARS

Excitement

The final exercise for the love category is used to gauge your actual excitement for the day to day work you would perform in the position. To determine this, answer the following questions.

- ♦ *Would/will you do this type of work, or something closely related, even if you were not being paid? Y/N*
- ♦ *Do you feel genuine excitement towards this work? Y/N*

If your answer to both of these questions is yes, then add a point to the love category. If it is not, then answer the following question.

- ♦ *Does this position provide you with unique and valuable experience and opportunity towards work that does genuinely interest and excite you? Y/N*

If the answer to this question is yes than add a half point to the love category. If the answer is no, then do not add anything to the love category and take extra caution when considering this role.

Now fill the total value for the love category (all three exercises scores added together) in the box below. This should be between 0 and 3.

LOVE SCORE:

Ikigai Categories: Skill

When the skill category is satisfied, you can feel confident in your position and that you are a valuable asset to an operation. This confidence will also provide a feeling of security that you are deserving of the position. This can be analysed by creating a personal SWOT (strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, threats) table and determining

how well of a technical fit you are for the role. The SWOT analysis also allows for you to consider how promising of an opportunity the role is. It is also important the role offers you ample space to grow your expertise and learn new skills, whether that's technical, interpersonal, or otherwise.

SWOT Analysis

A personal SWOT analysis allows you to objectively assess your strengths and how you can leverage them, and your weaknesses and what you should be aware of regarding them. The strengths and weaknesses sections are internal factors that are unique to you. The opportunities and weaknesses sections are external factors that can impact you. In this exercise you will be completing a personal SWOT table and comparing your results to the responsibilities and required experience of the position. This will allow you to objectively determine how qualified and unique

you are as candidate (and how unique the position is to you), which will give you a better understanding of your value to the organisation and hence your bargaining power. Several prompts are provided to assist you filling each section of the table.

STRENGTHS

- ♦ NATURAL TALENTS
- ♦ EXPERIENCE BASED TALENTS
- ♦ CONNECTIONS
- ♦ QUALIFICATIONS AND EXPERIENCE
- ♦ CHARISMA AND MORALS

WEAKNESSES

- ♦ BAD LIFE AND WORK HABITS
- ♦ LACK OF QUALIFICATIONS AND EXPERIENCE
- ♦ WHERE CAN YOU IMPROVE
- ♦ WHAT DO YOU AVOID OR FEAR

OPPORTUNITIES

- ♦ SKILLSET UNIQUENESS
- ♦ HIGH DEMAND FOR YOUR SKILLSET
- ♦ INDUSTRY GROWTH
- ♦ GAPS YOU COULD FILL
- ♦ NETWORKING OPPORTUNITIES

THREATS

- ♦ INDUSTRY SHRINKING
- ♦ SKILLSET LOSING INTEREST
- ♦ HIGH COMPETITION INDUSTRY

You should now examine your strengths and opportunities and try to find where there is overlap. Where is there ample opportunity for you to capitalise on your strengths? These are the areas where you can make a big impact and really shine. If you feel the job position aligns well with at least one of your strengths AND one of your opportunities, add one point to the skill category.

Now examine your weakness and threats and again look for overlap. In these areas external factors could cause your weaknesses to be limiting and severely decrease your effectiveness, so you should avoid them. If you feel the job position is **NOT** impacted by at least one weakness and one threat, then add another point to the skill category.

SKILL SCORE:

Opportunity for Growth

It is also important that you allow yourself room to improve and learn. Look back at your SWOT table and answer the following questions.

- ♦ Does the position allow me to improve my current strengths or gain new strengths? Y/N
- ♦ Does the position allow me to work on improving my weaknesses towards becoming strengths? Y/N
- ♦ Does the position provide me with new opportunities? Y/N
- ♦ Does the position mitigate my threats? Y/N

If you answered yes to two or more of these questions, then the position will likely offer you ample room to grow and you should add one point to the skill category. If you answered yes to less than two of these questions, you would likely have to search out ways to improve on your own behalf, so do not add anything.

Now fill the total value for the skill category (both exercise scores added together) in the box below. This should be between 0 and 3.

SKILL SCORE:

Ikigai Categories: Need

The need category represents the world's need for the work you would do and the vision your work contributes to. Feeling your work is important and that you are helping people can be a huge source of motivation and should not be overlooked. To evaluate this category, the ESG (environmental, social, governance) framework will be used to analyse the organisation's impact and sustainability, and the organisation's vision and mission statements will be revisited from a different perspective.

Sustainability (ESG Framework)

The ESG framework offers an insight into an organisation's sustainability. Many organisations self-report this information and it, or other information regarding their sustainability efforts, can often be found online. For this exercise investigate the organisation offering the job position under consideration. This will vary from organisation to organisation but look for things such as their carbon footprint and other impacts on the climate (environmental), how they give back to the community through programs and charity (social) and where they invest into other organisations and political entities (governance).

If they share data about and goals for improving their ESG or similar metrics, add one point to the need category. If you believe the organisation's influence in donation, investment and otherwise is creating a better future, add another point to the need category.

NEED SCORE:

Public Reception (Vision and Mission)

In this exercise you will revisit the organisation's vision and mission statements which you either found and wrote in the *Love: Goals (Vision and Mission)* section above. In that section you analysed how much these statements resonated with you personally. In this section you will be determining if the vision you would be working towards in this position is beneficial to the world, not just to you personally.

If you feel that the world will genuinely benefit from the vision of the organisation coming to fruition, add half a point to the need category. If you feel the general public would find the path laid out in their mission statement morally acceptable, add another half point to the need category.

Now fill the total value for the need category (both exercise scores added together) in the box below. This should be between 0 and 3.

NEED SCORE:

Ikigai Categories: Security

Finally, the security category ensures you will be paid fairly for your work and that the organisation is well established so there is not a high risk of the position being terminated or phased out. In other words this category ensures you can live comfortably now and have a stable path to do so in the future. This can be evaluated by comparing the position's salary and benefits to the average for the field and location and using Porter's five forces model to understand the organisation's place in the economy better.

Salary and Benefits

It is very important that you get back what you put in in the way of salary and benefits. If you already know the salary and benefits package which goes along with the position, then find the average salary for the position title in your area (can be found online by searching “average entry level mechanical engineer salary in Glasgow” for example) and the average overall salary in your area (for example “average salary in Glasgow”) and answer the following question.

- ♦ Is the position's salary at least 80% of the average salary for the role in the area? Y/N
- ♦ Is the position's salary at least 80% of the overall average salary in area? Y/N

If the answer to both of these questions is yes, then add one point to the security category. This is likely a fair pay.

If only one of these answers is yes, then only add half a point to the security category and consider why both are not yes. Does the line of work offer lower than average salaries? Is there a fair reason why you should be paid lower than average?

If both answers are no, do not add anything and seriously consider passing on this position. If the organisation cannot offer you a livable wage, you cannot realistically perform high level work or feel secure in your life.

If you do not know the position's salary, answer the following question.

- ♦ Is the average salary of the position title in the area at least 80% of the overall average salary in the area? Y/N

If the answer is yes, add one point to the security category. If the answer is no, do not add anything and ensure that the salary you are eventually offered is a livable wage.

Now look at the benefits the position offers or is likely to offer. Do these cover things like health and dental insurance? Are there other benefits that are useful to you such as paid gym membership? If you are happy with the benefits offered (or likely to be offered), add another half a point to the security category.

SECURITY SCORE: _____

Five Forces

Porter's five forces model provides a way to understand the organisation offering the position's place in its business environment. The five forces are the bargaining power of supplier, the bargaining power of buyers, threat of substitutes, threat of new entrants, and underpinning it all industry rivalry. Companies work to balance these five forces at all times to ensure they have solid footing. To see their current pace in this, conduct research to answer the following questions.

- ♦ Are there multiple good options of suppliers for any products the organisation offers? Y/N
- ♦ Is it easy for buyers to choose another option than the product or service offered by the organisation? Y/N
- ♦ Is the product and or service the organisation offers easily replaceable by other products and or services? Y/N
- ♦ Is there a low start-up cost for other organisations to enter the field? Y/N
- ♦ Are there direct competitors to the organisation that offer similar products and or services? Y/N

If the answer to all of these is no, then the organisation is very well placed in its market, and you should add one and a half points to the security category. If four are no, then add one point. If three are no, then add half a point. Otherwise do not add anything.

SECURITY SCORE:

Now fill the total value for the security category (both exercise scores added together) in the box below. This should be between 0 and 3.

SECURITY SCORE:

Putting It All Together

Now that you have a better understanding and a score for how the position performs in each of the four Ikigai categories, final analysis can be conducted, and advice given.

Firstly, add the four categories' values together. This should be in the range of 0 to 12. If this total value is 12, congratulations! You have likely found a stable position where you will feel driven, inspired, and comfortable, all while using and improving your expertise and earning a competitive salary — your Ikigai. More likely, if the total value is between 9 and 11.5, there may be some things to adapt to, but the position should be hopefully considered as it is likely a good fit. If the value is between 6 and 8.5, the position may be a good fit but would almost certainly not be perfect so should be considered cautiously. If the total value is between 0 and 5.5, the position will almost definitely leave you feeling something is lacking and it is not recommended to proceed.

If the total score falls in the range 6 to 11.5, use the next page to receive final advice. If you calculated less than 3 in a category, read that section. Then look at the Ikigai diagram below. Find the number which is the intersection of your categories which scored 2.5 or above and read it's entry on the next page.

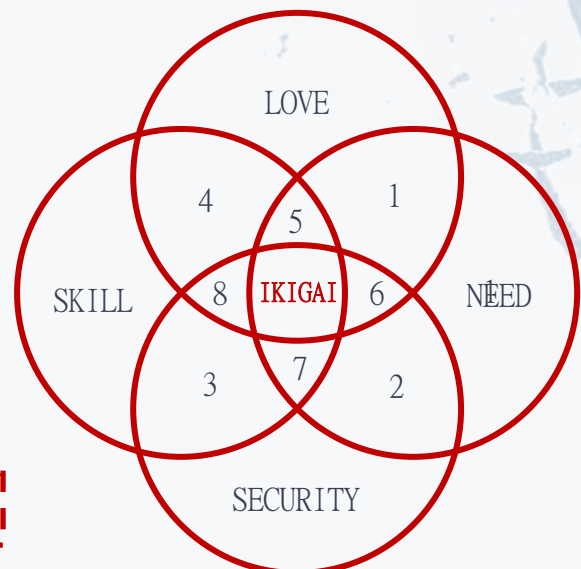
LOVE SCORE:

SKILL SCORE:

NEED SCORE:

SECURITY SCORE:

TOTAL IKIGAI SCORE:



LOVE

Would you be happy if it was your job until retirement?

SKILL

Can you prove yourself to be a valuable asset if someone else who's willing to work for cheaper comes along?

NEED

Would you be happy if your work was never used by others or if the world became a worse place because of your work?

SECURITY

Can you afford the life you want on the salary, and would you be able to find something else if you get laid off?

This position could ...

1. be your *mission*. You feel it is very important but lack skill and it is unstable.
2. be your *vocation*. There is a demand for it but to you it isn't exceptional.
3. be your *profession*. You don't love it but your skilled and it is stable.
4. be your *passion*. You love doing it but there's little demand.
5. give you a sense of enjoyment and purpose without stability.
6. offer you stability and excitement , but you may feel undeserving.
7. be stable and comfortable but boring.
8. be exciting and stable, but after a while you may begin to feel the work is pointless or detrimental.

You hopefully now have a much greater understanding of how the proposed position could fit into the life you want to build for yourself. Goodluck in your future endeavors!

References

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